GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

SOCIALISM ONLY WAY TO REMOVE POVERTY

P.M.'s INDEPENDENCE DAY SPEECH

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1888
August 15, 1966

Speaking from the ramparts of the Red Fort on occasion of the Independence Day, the Prime Minister, Srimati Indira Gandhi, said that India had accepted the socialist path because there was no other way of eradicating poverty. She appealed to the people to wage a relentless war against poverty.

In a reference to Mahatma Gandhi's message of non-violence, truth and Swadeshi, the Prime Minister said that this message held good even today. Non-violence meant that they should live in peace and amity. She wanted truth to pervade all actions. About Swadeshi, the Prime Minister said it was the duty of every citizen to popularise the Swadeshi movement.

Following is a full translation of the Prime Minister's Hindi speech:

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I greet my countrymen on this historic day from this historic place. Nineteen years ago, India turned a new leaf. There are certain historic events which leave a deep impress on the life of every individual. Our independence is one such event. Independence Day has special significance for us because on this day we began a new life. Nineteen years ago, the first Prime Minister of India, Jawaharlal Nehru, unfurled the national flag from the ramparts of the Red Fort. On this day, he lit the torch of freedom and laid the foundation of Independent India.

On this day, our minds turn to our great leaders and to innumerable people from all parts of the country who flung themselves into the freedom struggle and made immense sacrifices. They were truly great men. We owe our freedom to their courage, forbearance and sacrifice. The responsibility of following the path shown by these great sons of India has devolved on us.

Standing here on the ramparts of the Red Fort, my mind inevitably turns to India's past, a past studded with progress in the fields of science and philosophy and of other spheres. India was an advanced nation and had provided leadership to the world. How can we forget India's glorious past? It is for us to see that our historical record remains unblemished.

On this occasion, we naturally think of the Father of the Nation. I cannot do better than recall his message.

Jawaharlal----

Jawaharlal Nehru had once described Mahatma Gandhi as a magician. Despite his belief in science and the new World, Jawaharlal Nehru felt that the path shown by Mahatma Gandhi was the right path. 'Non-violence, 'Truth' and 'Swadeshi' summed up Gandhiji's message. It is my firm belief that this message still holds good. 'Non-violence' means that we should live in peace and amity, and entertain respect for one another's views. It also means that we should entertain respect for nations professing different ideologies. This word sums up our entire approach.

Similarly, we want Truth to pervade all our actions. We should not do anything which will not be in the interests of the nation. Fearlessness is an essential part of Truth. We should be as fearless today as we were during the struggle for freedom. We should not be afraid of making mistakes; we should not be afraid of making changes. We should be willing to adopt a new path and to imbibe new ideas. It is very necessary for us to have a complete understanding of the problems facing us. Only then can we find the way out.

'Swadeshi' is the third part of Gandhiji's message. The country is faced with economic difficulties. We can improve the economic situation by imbibing the spirit of Swadeshi. 'Swadeshi' does not mean that we do not import at all. It only means that we should exercise the utmost econom Patronise our own goods and make use of available resources. If, however, it becomes necessary to import with a view to learning new techniques, we should not hesitate to do so. The responsibility for popularising the Swadeshi movement

does not----

does not rest with the Government alone. Every citizen, be he a villager or a town-dweller, has to play an important part in popularising the Swadeshi movement.

SOCIALISM

We have accepted the socialist path because we feel that there is no other way of eradicating poverty. Democracy is the base of our socialism. Democracy confers many rights on the individual. But with these rights there are corresponding duties. One great duty is to help the nation achieve progress. We have launched many development programmes. The greatest before us is the removal of poverty. We have to wage a relentless battle against poverty. I appeal to my countrymen to join in this battle.

The peasantry is the most important wing of our society. They are also the predominant section of our population. I appeal to them to adopt modern techniques of agricultural production. I also need their cooperation in bringing about reforms in rural life.

The role of the labour is equally important. A great responsibility rests on their shoulders for increasing production, be it for defence or other purposes. By increasing production they will improve their own living standards and also help the nation in its march towards progress.

Our brave jawans are guarding our frontiers. Our hearts go out to them. Let us remember that our defences lie not only on the Himalayas but in every village, every town and every city. The peasantry, the labour, the industrialist, the businessman, the teacher and the employee have all an equally great

great responsibility in this task. Each one of them should discharge his responsibility faithfully. Truth and unity should be the foundations of our national life. Artists, writers and thinkers too have the responsibility of guiding the nation to the right path. They should not hesitate to imbibe new ideas from abroad. They should also see that our own ideas flow to other countries.

We have to continue our march towards progress. There can be no let-up. Many sections of our society have suffered from neglect for centuries. There are the harijans, the adivasis, the hill people and the minorities. We pay special attention to them. We have drawn up programmes for their welfare. But much more remains to be done. I am fully aware of their difficulties. Some of them suffered hardship during the recent drought. Without their uplift, the nation cannot make much progress. I appeal for their cooperation in the tasks facing the nation.

WOMEN

Then there are the women of India, belonging to all sections of society, and engaged in multifarious tasks. They also carry the responsibility of running the home, of bringing up the new generation and of braving the difficulties arising from spiralling prices. Women constitute 50 per cent. of the country's population. For centuries, they have imparted strength to the nation; for centuries, they have upheld the noble traditions of India. We look to them again to maintain the high traditions of our culture. They continue to be the source of the nation's strength. We look to them for inspiration. Indian women have been the embodiment of virtue.

Innumerable----

Innumerable people participated in the struggle for freedom. Many of them are not in our midst today. On this day, we pay our homage to them. Some of the freedom-fighters are old. We are benefiting by their experience.

A new generation is coming up. They were not witness to the freedom struggle. They are not aware of the fervour which impelled us to fight for freedom. Whether or not people were associated with the freedom struggle, whether they are young or old, the responsibility for the nation's progress and development rests on all squarely. If we work with dedication and determination, we can overcome our difficulties. If we march unitedly, we can remove all pressures on us - external pressures, pressures of poverty, pressures of disunity and many other pressures and difficulties. The heirs of Gandhi and Nehru and of other great leaders are capable of removing these pressures so that the march towards socialism continues.

We are faced with threats on our borders. We are also faced with the threat of poverty and backwardness inside the country. We cannot successfully fight the battle against poverty unless we accept new ideas, unless we do away with superstition, unless we work with dedication and determination to attain progress, unless we are prepared to make sacrifices in the face of difficulties. It is the duty of every individual to lend his cooperation in this great task. No one can absolve himself of this responsibility. We cannot remain idle spectators. We are all soldiers in the fight against poverty.

At the time of aggression on our borders, our young men, our students offered to lay down their lives to defend our-----

our territorial integrity. They were ready to write with their own blood a new chapter in the history of India. The nation beckons to them again. They should be ready to take up the challenge. They have to infuse a new life into the nation; they have to regenerate the nation.

We are assembled at the historic Red Fort today. The eyes of the entire nation are focussed on us. We have the panorama of Indian history behind us and we have the visions of a bright future before us. Every citizen should ask himself what he can contribute to the making of a bright future for the country. He should ask himself if the nation's policies and programmes can be successfully implemented. On an answer to the question depends our progress. If the people are assailed by doubts and hesitations, difficulties will naturally arise. But if they are resolved to accept the challenge, the nation can face the external and internal dangers and march towards progress. It is not an easy task. We never had any illusions about it. We may have made mistakes, we may not have moved with speed but it cannot be denied that many of our difficulties are the direct result of our progress and development. If we had remained static, may be our difficulties might not have increased but we would have remained a poor and suppressed nation. We purposely adopted the more difficult path of planned progress.

VIOLENCE

It is a matter of deep sorrow that we are deviating from the path of non-violence shown by Gandhiji. Violence is on the increase in India and abroad. There is only one way to

stop it----

stop it and that is to create an atmosphere in which violence cannot flourish. We all have a responsibility in creating the right atmosphere and the right outlook. It is the duty of the parents, the teachers and the citizens to ensure that destructive tendencies do not find any place in our scheme of things. They should popularise the right ideas. A halt in industrial production or a labour strike affects the labour family as much as the nation. Increased production brings prosperity to the nation and benefit to the labour.

Let us recapture the fervour which characterised our freedom struggle and work with dedication for a new revolution which will energise the whole nation, which will inspire us to answer the call of our motherland. I have absolutely no doubt that we have it in us to achieve great things. But if we stray from the right path, we will be heading towards ruin, and the sacrifices of the great sons of India would have been in vain. Let us draw inspiration from those fighters for freedom and keep the nation's flag flying.

'Jai Hind' is our national slogan. This slogan should give us self-confidence and confidence in the strength of our nation. It should inspire us to move forward. 'Jai Hind' represents our pledge to achieve all-round progress.

We extend our hand to friendly nations. Our sympathies are with the victims of colonialism. We will continue to raise our voice against injustice and war everywhere. We reiterate that our sympathies will always be with the victims of injustice.

We are-----

We are faced with difficulties. Side by side people have opportunities. The aspirations of the people have increased. We want our people to have more opportunities. We also want the subject people, the victims of oppression, everywhere in the world to breathe free air and to have full opportunities for progress.

I take a pledge on this day to work for the nation's uplift and to fight injustice everywhere. If we march unitedly as disciplined soldiers along the path shown by Gandhiji and Panditji, we can make India a great nation. Let us all take this pledge.

I call upon you to join me in raising the great slogan given by Netaji Subash Chander Bose and which is echoed through the length and breadth of the country. This slogan represents our strength. Join me in raising the slogan three times. Your voice is the voice of a great nation. It should reach the far-off mountains and to every nook and corner of India. The slogan should inspire courage and self-confidence in every Indian.

JAI HIND.

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